SA State Emergency Service





Community Engagement Strategic Directives

2024-2029



Government of South Australia

SES RESCUE

SASES acknowledge and pay our respect to Aboriginal people as the state's first peoples and nations, and recognise them as traditional owners and occupants of land and waters in South Australia.



Our Vision

A reliable and trusted volunteer-based organisation building safe and resilient communities.

Our Purpose

To create safer communities by partnering with them to prepare for and respond to extreme weather conditions including heat, storm, and flood.

Values

The values represented within this body of work reflect those of the South Australian State Emergency Service (SASES) and align with the South Australian Government's Public Sector Values and Behaviour Framework. The values inform our day-to-day activities and underpin collective approaches to sustaining a positive value-based culture – our people, our way of working, our behaviours and our community value1

Purpose of the Community Engagement Strategic Directives

Our purpose in updating these strategic directives is to build on the existing work that has been undertaken during 2018-2023 and incorporate lessons learnt within the community engagement area. This is also a time for celebrating our significant achievements. Looking forward to how we will continue to grow this capability, making an impact by encouraging and supporting South Australians to develop and strengthen their disaster resilience.

Community engagement principles

These strategic directives reflect the following community engagement principles outlined in the AIDR National Strategy for Disaster Resilience Handbook 2020. The principles are reflected in the Community Engagement Model for Emergency Management (Page x, Fig1). The following principles: Understand the community, its capacities, strengths and priorities, Recognise Complexity and Partner with community to support existing networks and resources, all serve as statements of good practice when planning for effective community engagement.

Understand the community, its capacities, strengths, and priorities

In the SASES, we use a strengths-based approach, where everyone in the community, with the right tools and supports can make some decisions about their emergency planning. Using local approaches we will continue to listen to, learn from and create meaningful engagement activities. We aim to leverage the wealth of knowledge that communities and our volunteers hold about their, levels of awareness and preparedness, capabilities, challenges, and external impacts.
Understanding community involves:

- Respecting and using local knowledge and experience
- Tapping into existing networks
- Using genuinely respectful and flexible approaches
- Identifying and addressing barriers to engagement and making participation accessible to all
- Recognising that communities change and evolve over time [6]

Recognise Complexity

As part of enhancing disaster resilience, we recognise challenges that are a part of the process of working in partnership with community. To better understand the needs of the South Australian community, we need to be mindful of a range of influencing factors including an ageing population, elevated levels of low literacy and numeracy, cultural diversity, geographic isolation, poor infrastructure, and poverty. We also recognise the inherent challenges of differences in life experience, opinion, knowledge, resources, and capacity.
Recognising complexity involves:

- Embracing and respecting difference and diversity, including different perceptions of risk
- Using genuinely respectful and flexible approaches
- Identifying and addressing barriers to engagement and making participation accessible to all
- Recognising that communities evolve and change over time [7]

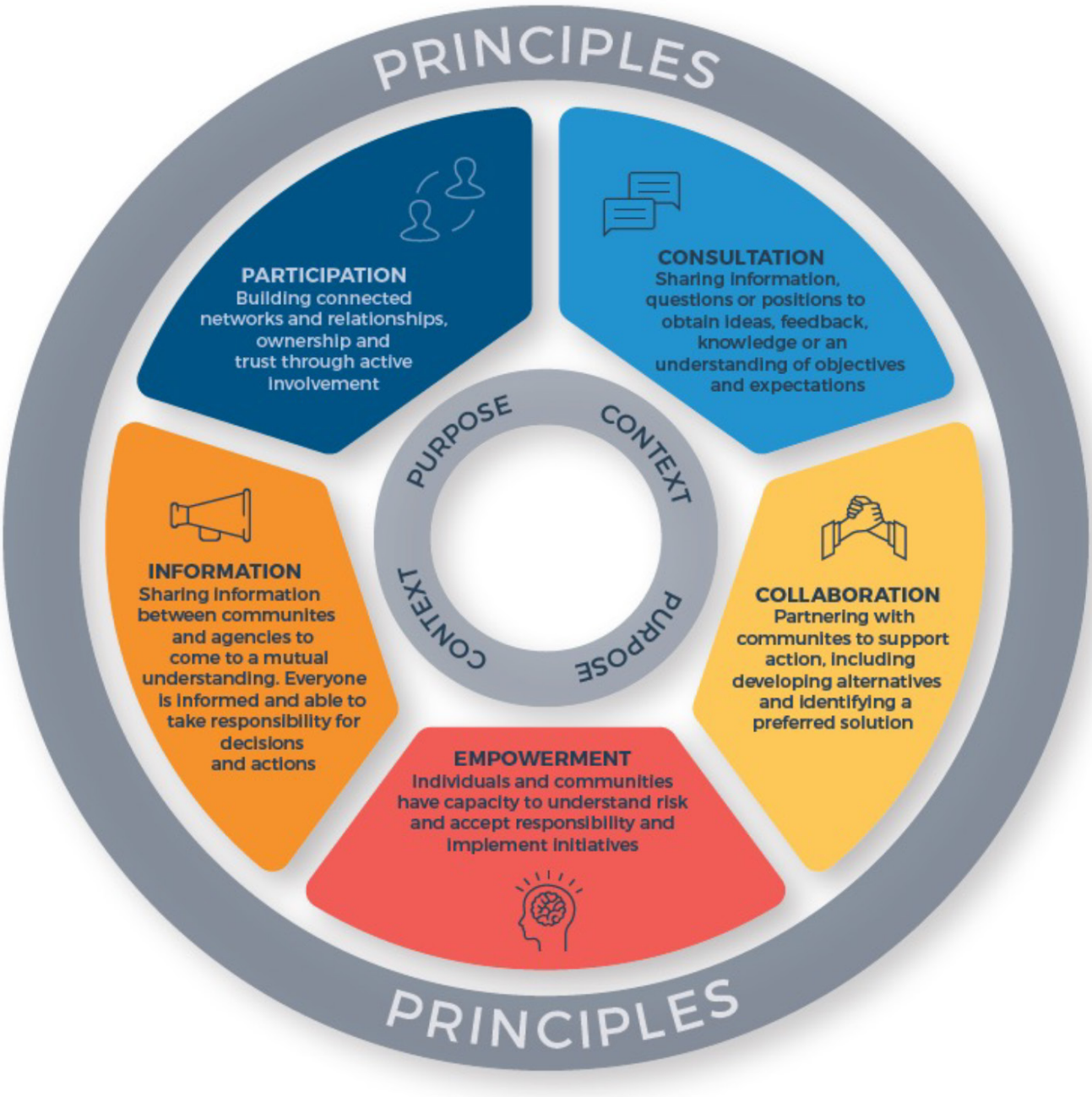
Partner with community to support existing networks and resources

Community are the experts of their own lives, and we will continue to partner with them in meaningful, genuine ways to support local actions that reduce their risks. We understand that the disaster resilience space is one that is rich in variety, experience, and knowledge. To ensure that community knowledge and experience has a voice at the table we will seek to coordinate with other disaster resilience focused agencies and organisations to provide the best possible experience for all members of the community to be engaged and empowered in their preparedness journey.
Partnering with the community to support existing networks and resources involves:

- building and maintaining partnerships
- fostering relationships with community leaders
- respecting community choices
- aligning emergency management activities to build on existing social capital
- identifying and employing strategies that empower local action.[8]

6, 7 & 8 AIDR National Strategy for Disaster Resilience Handbook 2020

Community Engagement Model for Emergency Management



Community Engagement Model for Emergency Management - National Stratergy for Disaster Resilience

The Community Engagement Model for Emergency Management is circular to show that one engagement approach is not necessarily better than any other, and that different approaches are legitimate depending on the purpose and context of a particular situation.[9]
In developing this strategy, we have a focus on community engagement activities that are coordinated, inclusive of diverse community needs and empower community to plan for and take protective actions for extreme weather events.

Why we do community engagement and where we have come from

'Building upon our existing emergency planning arrangements, we need to focus more on action-based resilience planning to strengthen local capacity and capability, with greater emphasis on community engagement and a better understanding of the diversity, needs, strengths and vulnerabilities within communities. Disasters do not impact everyone in the same way, and it is often our vulnerable community members who are the hardest hit. '

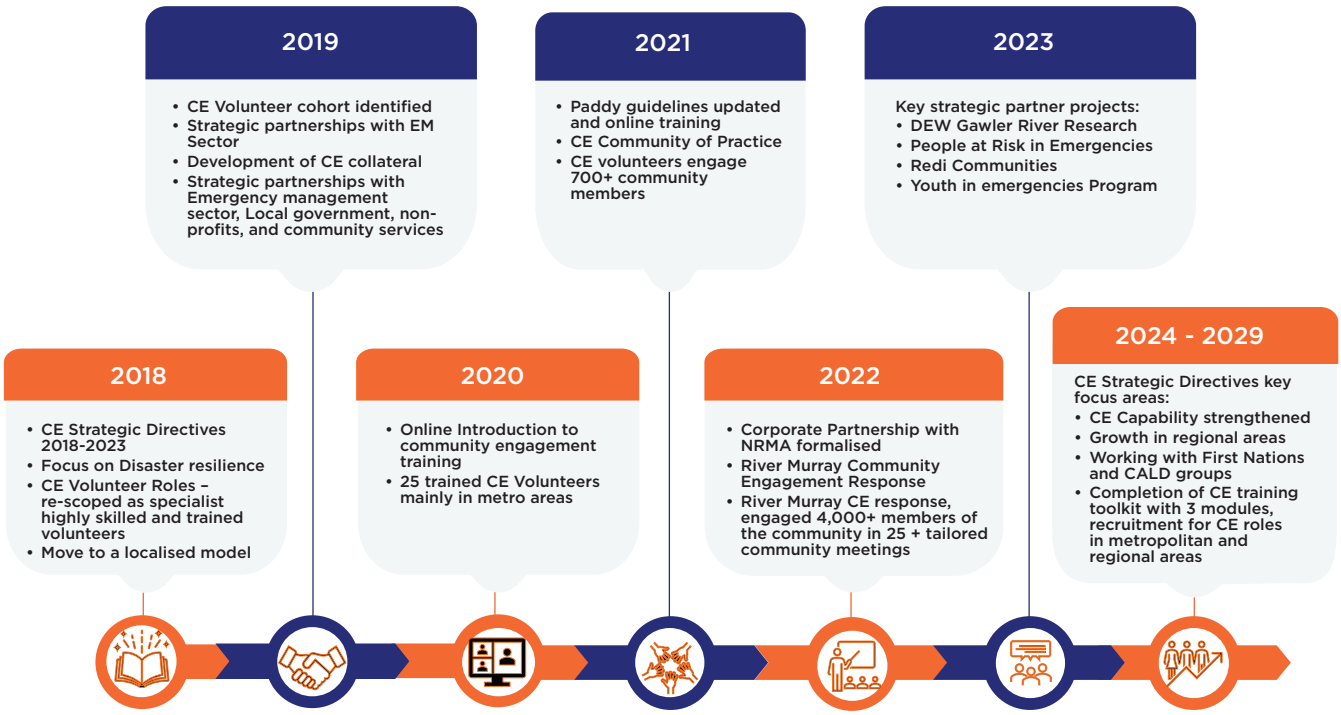
National Strategy for Disaster Resilience (COAG, 2011)

Community Engagement has been recognised nationally as a key component of frontline emergency services and is a foundation for creating disaster resilient communities. With the increase of severe and more frequent extreme weather events, SASES has a role in ensuring that communities are engaged, educated, and empowered to plan and prepare for emergencies.

The first Community Engagement Strategic Directives 2018-2023 focused on developing and growing the community engagement capability with a disaster resilience focus. In line with national best practice there was a requirement for the community engagement capability to evolve from a centralised model into one that embraces local, targeted, and tailored approaches. This has enabled leveraging of local knowledge, creating behaviour change and shared responsibility in building disaster resilient communities. All of this required significant changes in policy, procedures and processes as can be seen reflected in the Community Engagement Evolution 2018-2029 *diagram 2*. The focus has been to develop and uplift the community engagement capability embedding it as an important part of frontline services.

Community Engagement Evolution 2018 - 2028

Diagram 2



Tailoring Community Engagement – the way forward

We acknowledge that there is no one size fits all model and that our communities are rich in diversity and going forward there is a requirement to adapt our engagement activities to better suit community needs.

In South Australia we live in a diverse community with over 24% of people who speak a language other than English and about half of all adults have poor or very poor literacy and numeracy skills[2]. There are currently over 118,000 people who have some form of disability[2] People with a disability are disproportionately impacted by disaster events. They are two to four times more likely to die in a disaster, experience higher risk of injury and loss of property, have greater difficulty evacuating, sheltering, and require more intensive health and social services during and after disasters [3].
Our first nations people are often disproportionately affected by disasters and historically first nations people's knowledge regarding preparing for, coping with, and recovering from disasters has been overlooked4. We also have the highest proportion of older people on mainland Australia with more than 630,000 people aged over 505.

These are all examples of some of the members of our community who may require tailored engagement approaches that can assist them to identify their risk and take appropriate protective actions. Included in these communities are those who will need additional support to help them prepare for emergencies and emergency services must find ways to work in partnership with organisations that support them. Once communities have identified their risks, and make the necessary preparations, they will be better equipped to adapt plans to suit their personal circumstances and the dynamic nature of emergencies during the response phase.

2 Australian Bureau of Statistics Census 2021
3 Michelle Villeneuve, Disability-Inclusive Emergency Planning: Person-Centred Emergency Preparedness.
4 PAHO & WHO 2014, UNDRR 2015
5 South Australia's Plan for Ageing Well 2020-2025

Key Deliverables

Key Deliverables 2024-2029

Starting with a small cohort of enthusiastic volunteers, we have seen a significant growth in community engagement volunteers in the metropolitan and regional areas. This has included uplifting of the community engagement roles, Community Engagement Coordinator and Community Engagement Crew, online skills development training, and development of presentations and resources. We aim to build on this success by using flexible approaches across the state, developing and adapting resources, leveraging key stakeholder relationships, amplifying our key messages in the community, and developing our operational community engagement roles.

There are five key deliverables for the Community Engagement Strategic Directives 2024-2029, these include:

- Grow Community Engagement Capability
- Strategic Partnerships
- Expand the Toolkit and Adapt Collateral
- Campaign and Key Messages
- Community Liaison Officer Role

Grow the Community Engagement (CE) Capability

Objective

Recruit and train Community Engagement (CE) volunteers across the state with a focus on building disaster resilience knowledge, and engagement skills, along with local knowledge that can be utilised to educate the community, using standardised key messaging.

Overarching Strategy

Going forward our focus is on supporting existing CE volunteers and strengthening the CE capability further with coordinated recruitment for both existing and new volunteers within metropolitan and regional areas. Working with leadership and the recruitment team we will create flexible options for regional units when there is limited volunteer capacity, we will seek to be innovative and apply other approaches including a district model. Building on the work that began in Introduction to Engagement three new modules were created. Module one – Introduction to Community Engagement and Module two – Planning are both online self-paced modules. Module three – Presentation Techniques format is a face-to-face workshop.

Actions

Recruiting new volunteers in both metropolitan and regional areas that self-identify for CE with the support of Unit Leadership

Working with regional leadership to develop flexible approaches including district models that better suit regional units

6-8 Community Engagement Virtual Communities of practice including 1-2 face to face meetings annually

CE Modules 1 and 2 are online and will have ongoing intakes during the year

CE Module 3 will be presented face-to-face quarterly by the CE team

Develop, adapt and facilitate training for CE Volunteers, including; How to run street corner meetings and Conflict Resolution

Expand the Toolkit and Adapt Collateral

Objective

The Community Engagement (CE) toolkit will continue to reflect our diverse communities and have multiple tools that CE volunteers can access to contribute to their event planning and presentations. Collateral will be updated to be relevant and consistent with our key messages as well as adapted for specific community needs.

Overarching Strategy

To further support our trained CE volunteers, we will ensure that key preparedness messages are delivered consistently across the state, as we continue to develop and refine the community engagement toolkit. This will include tailored presentations; session plans and identifying new community engagement activities. Our suite of brochures and animations will continue to be updated and adapted for different communities including remote APY Lands, first nations, taking advice from first nations communities and multicultural peak bodies and developing materials in a range of formats. We will also explore the feasibility of developing a program and activities targeted at Youth.

Actions

Develop tailored presentations for: Culturally and Linguistically Diverse Communities, those with a Disability, First Nations communities and other specialist groups

Include panel style events as part of the CE range of activities with a focus on one hazard such as Storm, Heat or Floods

Explore developing a youth education program, including reviewing other emergency services education programs and products

Develop new Heatwave and Flood collateral for APY lands based on feedback from focus groups

Update our collateral suite with translations in new and emerging language groups as identified through Australian Bureau of Statistics and other government departments

Review, consumer test and where necessary update the Storm, Flood, and heatwave collateral on a 3 yearly cycle

Utilise monitoring and evaluation frameworks to report on and measure the success of our engagement activities

Strategic Partnerships

Objective

Work collaboratively with internal and external stakeholders including emergency services, local councils, national and state peak bodies, non-government organisations and community groups. We will continue to leverage existing partnerships, as well as forging new partnerships that are focused on building disaster resilient communities.

Overarching Strategy

Continue to build on our relationships that are focused on working with diverse members of our community. These include relationships with other emergency services, state, federal and local government, non-for-profit organisations and community groups. We will work in partnership with stakeholders on mutually beneficial projects. Seeking new opportunities to work with these organisations that have clients with an elevated disaster risk. This includes industries such as aged care and disability services. We also seek to develop a sustainable respectful relationship with our first nations communities and culturally and linguistically diverse groups. We will continue to collaborate, share knowledge, and shape Community Engagement practice through our involvement within the AFAC network.

Actions

Engage with organisations such as those in the disability or aged care field with at risk clients, delivering disaster risk education with staff who will then engage with clients around their home emergency plans

Build strategic relationships with key APY, Indigenous and multicultural stakeholders that are based on mutual respect and flexibility

Identify projects with other emergency services, state and local government and non-profit organisations focused on building community disaster resilience

Continue to work with District Officers and regional leadership to determine targeted areas of focus

Continue to represent SASES through quarterly meetings on the AFAC Community Engagement Technical Group and the Community Safety Group

Identify key projects to collaborate with our corporate sponsor NRMA that meet SA SES disaster resilience goals

Utilise NRMA research resources, to assist with identifying at-risk communities, and developing targeted community engagement activities

Community Liaison Officer

Objective

To provide timely, appropriate, and engaging operational community engagement activities, within the Public Information function when required. During significant events, we have seen firsthand the importance of identifying and running targeted, local, community activities. These activities are critical to increasing community awareness and encouraging preparedness activities that have a direct influence on the communities understanding of the risk and ways to mitigate this risk.

Overarching Strategy

We are committed to growing this capability within our existing workforce through, promoting the role of Community Liaison Officer, providing training and opportunities for mentoring before stepping into the role. Where possible we will also explore the use of trained community engagement volunteers as community meeting facilitators. This may also include running street corner meetings, attending stakeholder meetings and briefings as well as any additional training and mentoring involved to equip people with the skills needed to do the roles.

Actions

Involvement in the development and use of the operational community engagement pathway with staff and volunteers to introduce the role and identify a cohort of interested staff

Provide training and mentoring opportunities during activations

Explore a potential annual exercise to ensure skills are up to date

Support a cohort of trained community engagement volunteers with further training and mentoring to run operational community meetings

Campaign and Key Messages

Objective

We will continue to build on the work, started with our corporate partner NRMA Insurance in the inaugural 2024 Storm preparedness campaign. Our focus is to continue with this work to strengthen SASES brand awareness and embed our key preparedness messaging for storm and extreme weather within South Australia.

Overarching Strategy

Working within the funding scope we will seek to utilise a range of media methods, including print, digital media and where possible television, to give us the best possible reach and message cut through across the state. We will expand the work completed in the previous campaign, where we will adapt our key messages for different community members targeting regional communities and Culturally and Linguistically Diverse groups based on local knowledge and NRMA research and data from the Australian Bureau of Statistics.

Actions

Collaborate with NRMA Insurance and SASES leadership to plan and develop the extreme weather awareness campaign

Liaise with all relevant SASES business areas in development and execution of the plan

For new campaigns build in pre and post research to determine knowledge of risk and preparedness actions as well as communities to target

Develop targeted campaign messaging for specific community cohorts such as CALD and First Nations groups

Review end of campaign reports and implement changes for future campaigns

Essential success Factors

Internal Partnerships

Internal partnerships remain critical to the further growth of the Community Engagement capability. This area works closely with recruitment, training, operations, and the communications team. We will continue to strengthen relationships, share, and seek support, and actively look for opportunities to collaborate on mutually beneficial projects, communicating our outcomes across business units. As this area continues to grow it is important to recognise that building a more disaster resilient South Australia is an important part of the core function of the SASES.

Targeted, Trusted Local Engagement

The Community Engagement volunteers will complete online training modules, participate in Communities of Practice, and ongoing skills development. Tapping into local knowledge at their unit and in the leadership team and the latest statistics through the ABS they will deliver community engagement activities that are tailored and adapted for their unique community needs. Understanding that to influence positive behaviour change, building trust is a key component they will continue to display a consistently high level of professional behaviour when engaging with the community.

Conclusion

This body of work represents the Community Engagement Strategic Directions over the next five-year period. These directives aim to strengthen the capacity building that has happened in the previous five years and build disaster resilience through a strength's-based engagement model.

Effective engagement is recognised nationally as a central pillar in building disaster resilient communities. These recommendations are focused on building capacity within the community engagement space.

Related Documents

This strategy has linkages with the the following documents:

South Australian State Emergency Service
Annual Business Plan 2024-2025

South Australian State Emergency Service
Community Engagement Strategic Directions 2028-2023

South Australian State Emergency Service
Public Information Manual, Community Liaison

AIDR Community Engagement for Disaster
Resilience Handbook 2020

Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk
Reduction 2015-2030

Further Reading

Natural hazards Research Australia - Resilient Communities research
Resilient communities | Natural Hazards Research Australia

AFAC Climate Change and Disasters 2020
afac-climate-change-and-disasters_key-messages-and-resources_nov-2020.pdf

Disability-Inclusive Emergency Planning: Person-Centred Emergency Preparedness
Person-Centred Emergency Preparedness (PCEP) User Guide

South Australian's Plan for Ageing Well 2020-2025
South+Australia's+Plan+for+Ageing+Well+2020-2025_WEB.pdf


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